



Journeys: a poet's diary

Bruce King

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the analytical groundwork for the All-India Progressive Writers Association (AIPWA) and its first conference in Lucknow (1936).

Coppola's nuanced account of AIPWA's political and literary development includes its nationalist commitment and its pro-Soviet, pro-Allied World War II role. The years 1937–47 are considered the AIPWA's "Years of Power" (169) as it gathered strength in that period. The Urdu section (UPWA) was particularly prominent and its publications included important journals such as *Naya Adab* (New literature). However, Coppola attributes "the first major breach within the UPWA" (184) to this era: an essay by Ahmed Ali, dividing Progressives into "a political section" and "creative section" (184), placed Anand and Zaheer in the former group, and Ali himself, Faiz Ahmed Faiz and others in the latter. Ali objected to the AIPWA's Marxist alignment since 1936, which had led to an emphasis on proletarian literature. Ali soon broke away; in time, Raipuri and others did too.

Coppola's writes of India's division into the independent countries of India and Pakistan in 1947, and the impact of Cold War politics on both. The Indian Progressive Writers Association was allied with the Communist Party of India (CPI), which opposed the Nehru government; its highly politicized literary activities led to dissent, and then marginalization after the 1970 Afro Asian Writers Conference in Delhi. The Pakistani Progressive Writers Association's links to the Communist Party of Pakistan (CPP) was considered a security risk, due to Pakistan's anti-Soviet alliance with the United States. In 1951 Faiz and Zaheer were accused and jailed (but later exonerated) in the Rawalpindi Conspiracy case, a suspected left-wing military coup. Finally, in 1958, the martial law authorities seized the influential newspaper group Progressive Papers.

However, Progressives in India and Pakistan maintained friendships and literary links, despite Indo Pakistan hostilities. Coppola's last five chapters – each devoted to a different poet: Faiz, Asrarul Haq Majaz, Makhdum Mohiuddin, Ali Sardar Jafri and Sahir Ludhianvi – provide a lyrical celebration of timeless poetry by exceptional writers inspired by the Progressive Writers Movement, which gave Urdu a new voice. This is a truly informative, profound and thought-provoking book on a remarkable body of work and its writers.

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Journeys: a poet's diary, by A.K. Ramanujan, edited by Krishna Ramanujan and Guillermo Rodriguez, Hyryanda, Penguin India Random House/Hamish Hamilton, 2019, 380 pp., Rupees 599 (hardback), ISBN 978-0-670-092086

Arun Kolatkar, Jayanta Malhapatra, Agha Shahid Ali, and Arvind Krishna Mehrotra each have claims and sponsors to be considered India's greatest modern poet, but if you polled poets as well as editors of international anthologies, the title would probably still go to A.K. Ramanujan, although until Guillermo Rodriguez's (2016) dense, comprehensive and authoritative *When Mirrors are Windows: A View of A.K. Ramanujan's Poetics* there was little to aid the reader beyond, for example, the far more introductory chapters in my *Three Indian*

Poets: Nissim Ezekiel, Dom Moraes, A. K. Ramanujan (King [1991] 2005). Rodriguez along with Ramanujan's son Krishna have now brought us, with a useful foreword by famous Kannada dramatist, film director and Ramanujan's longtime friend, Girish Karnad, a selection of diaries, journals, drafts of poems, fragments, notes and other thoughts spanning 1949–93: from a young lecturer in India to Ramanujan's later international fame as poet, translator, folklorist, linguist and theorist.

As with Rodriguez's *Mirrors*, the material is based on the A.K. Ramanujan Special Collection in the University of Chicago Library; in an irony Ramanujan would have enjoyed, to research Indian literary culture it is increasingly necessary to consult American university libraries. As Ramanujan was guarded, discrete, ironic, amusing and oblique when self-revealing, *Journeys* is as close as we are likely to get to the inner man who throughout his life was plagued by insecurities, distrusted ambition, avoided self-promotion, was conscious of his small physical stature, self-analytical, and disliked offering opinions and assertions. Born a Brahmin he remained scholarly and puritanical, but he also practised a consciously Buddhist avoidance of desire and attraction. His journals were a diary, a way to find materials and consistency in a life teeming with varied reading, ideas, travel, experience, friends and stories.

As a diary they are good reading but more fragmentary than autobiographical. Here is Ramanujan's first trip from India (1959) as he meets many new people and tells himself to be open to new experiences – a view he retained throughout his life; here is an unexpected 1971 mescaline trip filled with desire for and arguments with his wife, along with the hope that it will provide material for poems; here is his famous discovery of an anthology of ancient Dravidian poetry in the University of Chicago library and his remaking the poems into modern English equivalents, seeking new forms, English word order, assonance, and rhymes to suggest the characteristics of the originals while avoiding the archaism and woodenness of translation. Ramanujan the scholar was as a poet a follower of Ezra Pound's modernist make-it-new view of translation.

There are numerous photographs here of Ramanujan in which he appears small, slight, out of place and oversensitive, which I find revealing; even as an internationally famous scholar and poet he remained insecure, vulnerable, self-conscious. He wanted to be an all-round intellectual, but closely followed the conventions of academic disciplines.

Karnad's foreword is itself a revelation. He and Ramanujan were both influenced by local modernist literary movements (a major subject awaiting scholarship is modernism in the Indian regional literatures). The then editor of Oxford University Press India thought Ramanujan's poems chopped-up prose and told Karnad only to forward the manuscript to England if he made it clear that this was Karnad's personal decision, and, even then, only by slow sea-post. When the poems were praised in England the editor said let England pay for the publicity.

Much of Ramanujan's career seems accidental, which possibly explains the amusing ironies of the poetry. At the University of Chicago, a Fulbright Fellow, he began teaching Indian languages as a replacement teacher. As he had not then published scholarship he was granted tenure on the basis of his poetry. No wonder the poetry implies that life appears accidental but is rooted in the past; how can you predict an inherited trait, or even know which tree might be the source of a seedling? The *Journeys* show Ramanujan was always self-questioning, searching, experiencing and writing. His posthumous works in English, including translations from his writings in Kannada, will soon outnumber those published during his lifetime and put the fullness of his accomplishment and personal and cultural contexts into perspective. Let them continue, but please in future include an index of people, topics and poems, which is lacking here.

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Why should I write a poem now: The letters of Srinivas Rayaprol and William Carlos Williams, 1949–1958, edited by Graziano Krätli, Foreword by Arvind

Krishna Mehrotra, Afterword by Paul Mariani, Regencies series, Albuquerque, University of New Mexico Press, 2018, xxii + 214 pp., \$65 (hardback), ISBN 978 0 8263 5996 4

This small book is a cornucopia of literary, cultural and even political history, and should breed other books and scholarly articles by those seeking untrodden paths. It is also an excellent read as both Rayaprol and Williams were natural letter writers, often commenting upon their personal life, plans, career and emotions. Williams was then suffering from strokes and the effects of ageing. The book includes letters between Rayaprol and James Laughlin (poet, owner of New Directions publishing house and editor of its influential annual anthologies), letters between Rayaprol and *Poetry* magazine (to Karl Shapiro and Henry Rago), and even the table of contents to the five issues of *East and West*, the international journal that Rayaprol published on his own in India and included writers like Williams, James Purdy and Henry Miller. I wish the endnotes were embedded in the text as I often consulted them.

Rayaprol, the son of a Telegu poet and civil engineer, was sent to Stanford University to study civil engineering. While in the USA he took a poetry course with the conservative poet and literary critic Yvor Winters and, convinced that Winters was wrong, he began contacting the American modernists associated with New Directions publications, especially those in its annual *Anthology*, and William Carlos Williams, Winters's *bête noir*. Williams was one of the great American modernists, acquainted with Pound and Stevens, a democratic vernacularist concerned with the significance of the ordinary, who opposed T.S. Eliot's idealization of European history and high culture. Charles Olson, Robert Creeley, Allen Ginsberg, the Beats, in England Charles Tomlinson, and in India Arun Kolatkar were all influenced by Williams. Probably internationally the most important American poet since Walt Whitman, and often for similar reasons, Williams's focus was on the actual, the local, especially as found in language and speech.

Rayaprol unwillingly returned to India; he had a successful career as a civil engineer, but living in Secunderabad he missed the birth of the new modern Indian poetry in English that was then taking place in Mumbai, New Delhi, Calcutta and a few other cities. He contributed to the US literary journals that were then discovering writing outside the USA. He published a few volumes with P. Lal's Writers Workshop and with limited success tried to gain the interest of James Laughlin and